

MUSHARRAF'S LAST STAND?

TIED IN KNOTS:
Pervez Musharraf

How the General fares in the war with the extremists and whether the deal with PPP materialises will shape his fate

■ By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi

In an ironic twist of fate, the Pakistan Supreme Court's (sc) July 20 decision to restore Chief Justice Iftikhar M. Chaudhry and to throw out the Government's reference against him might have brought a strange sense of relief to embattled President General Pervez Musharraf.

The landmark sc decision is being hailed by analysts as the first instance of the apex judicial body ruling directly against a sitting military establishment. They point out that throughout Pakistan's chequered history, sc had always sided with military establishments in issues related to their legitimacy, even coining the much-abused concept of 'the Law of Necessity' to justify military coups. The recent ruling, according to political pundits, has given a sorely-needed backbone to the judiciary and raised its stature in the eyes of the masses.

When the President moved against the chief justice on March 9, for alleged nepotism and judicial misconduct, he could not



THE GENERAL HAS DECLARED THAT THIS IS AN OPEN WAR BETWEEN THE EXTREMISTS AND THE MODERATES.